

THICKER THAN MUD.

A kavatender’s guide to organizing your bar: your rights, the tactics that win, and who’s got your back.

THE BAR RUNS ON US.

Kava bars sell community, a “second home.” We build it: brewing mud before open, straining till our forearms burn, closing alone at 2 a.m., smiling for tips.

ONE OF US COMPLAINING IS A PROBLEM. ALL OF US TOGETHER IS A UNION.

SOUND FAMILIAR? CHECK WHAT’S TRUE AT YOUR BAR:

- [ ] Brewing, prepping or cleaning off the clock
- [ ] A tip pool that a manager or owner dips into
- [ ] Paid on a 1099 like a contractor, scheduled and trained like an employee
- [ ] Closing alone with impaired or hostile customers
- [ ] Schedules posted last minute; hours cut when you speak up
- [ ] “We’re a family here,” said right before bad news

IN FLORIDA, SINCE SEPT 30, 2026

Minimum wage: **$15.00/hr.** Tipped: **$11.98 + tips.** If tips don't get you to $15 every hour, the bar owes the gap.

KNOW YOUR RIGHTS.

Section 7 of the National Labor Relations Act protects workers who act **together** to improve pay and conditions. No union needed yet.

YOU CAN LEGALLY:

→ Compare pay and tips with coworkers

→ Talk union on breaks and off the clock

→ Sign a union card

→ Bring a group complaint or petition to the boss

→ Post about conditions online, with coworkers

THE ONLY TIPS THE BOSS CAN'T TAKE:

- **T** **Threaten** firing, cut hours, or closing the bar
- **I** **Interrogate** you about who's involved
- **P** **Promise** raises or perks to drop the union
- **S** **Spy** on your meetings or chats, or act like it

Shift leads: if they can hire, fire or discipline, the law likely counts them as management. Keep them out early.

Small bars: the NLRB generally covers retail and restaurants grossing $500k+ a year. A single small shop may fall below. Ask an organizer.

Retaliated against? You have 6 months to file a charge. Log dates, names, texts, screenshots.

FROM SHELL TO CONTRACT.

01 **Talk.** Quietly, one-on-one, with coworkers you trust. Listen more than you pitch.

02 **Build a committee.** 3–5 people others respect, covering openers, closers and weekends.

03 **Map the bar.** Who works when, who's close to whom, who people actually listen to.

04 **Pick the fight.** The issue nearly everyone feels: off-clock brewing, tips, safety at close.

05 **Get backup.** Contact EWOC or a union (see contacts at the back) before anything goes public.

06 **Sign cards.** Aim for a supermajority, 70% or more, while the boss still doesn't know.

07 **Go public.** Ask the owner to recognize your union, or file with the NLRB. Filing takes 30% on cards; winning takes a majority of votes cast.

08 **Bargain.** A written contract is where raises, fair tip rules and safety get locked in.

CARDS AREN'T VOTES. KEEP TALKING UNTIL THE BALLOTS ARE COUNTED.

TACTICS THAT WIN.

THE ONE-ON-ONE IS EVERYTHING. RUN IT A-E-I-O-U:

Agitate	What's wrong here? Let them talk.
Educate	Who decides? Not us, alone.
Inoculate	Here's what the boss will say.
Organize	Will you come to the next meeting?
Unionize	Will you sign a card today?

Organize the whole bar, not just your friends. Every shift, brewers and barbacks too. A union of only the closing crew is a clique, and the boss will treat it like one.

Build a cushion. Support sags once the boss pushes back. Don't go public on a bare majority.

Escalate in steps. Petition, then deliver it together, then a pin day, then bigger. Every action tests your numbers and grows them.

Bring in the regulars. Kava bars live on community. Regulars who sign a support letter or wear your pin are leverage an owner can't shrug off.

Write it all down. Keep a private, shared log of every violation: date, time, who, what.

THE BOSS'S PLAYBOOK.

NAME EVERY MOVE BEFORE THEY MAKE IT.

"We're a family." Families don't cut your hours for asking questions.

The surprise raise. At a Kentucky distillery, raises and perks landed right before workers voted the union down. The NLRB ruled the company broke the law.

"Got a minute? Just us." Keep it short. You never have to say where you stand.

"We'll have to close." Threatening closure over a union is illegal. Write it down, word for word.

Divide and conquer. Best shifts for the loyal, openers against closers. Stay one crew.

SECURITY CULTURE

- Personal phones only. Never bar Wi-Fi or the staff group chat.
- Signal, with disappearing messages on.
- Meet off-site, never at the bar.
- Nobody who can hire, fire or discipline.
- Write like the owner will read it: facts only.

IT'S BEEN DONE.

HOUSE OF KAVA · BROOKLYN

The borough's first kava bar. Workers organized over pay, scheduling and boundaries; nearly all of them struck, and about 400 people signed a support letter. The owner held out, so the crew kept its union and partnered with another café.

ATTABOY · NEW YORK · 2026

Cocktail bar staff built their own independent union, Attaboy Local 134, won their vote 13–8, and headed into first-contract bargaining.

DEATH & CO · NEW YORK

All 17 workers signed cards with help from Workers United, and the drive still fell short. Cards are the start line, not the finish.

THE LAW · OCT 2026

The NLRB has had a working Board since January. In August the Senate confirmed a third Republican member, so worker-friendly rules from 2022–23 may be reversed.

Cemex lets the Board order a law-breaking boss to bargain. One appeals court rejected it in March; another upheld it in April. Don’t build your plan on it.

Your Section 7 rights are in the statute itself. Regional offices still run elections and take charges.

WHO’S GOT YOUR BACK.

EWOC · Free training and a volunteer organizer matched to your bar. Start here.

workerorganizing.org

Workers United · The SEIU union behind Starbucks Workers United. Organizes cafés and bars.

workersunited.org

UNITE HERE · The hospitality union: food service, hotels, bars.

unitehere.org

Labor Notes · Organizer trainings, guides and a big yearly conference.

labornotes.org

NLRB · File a charge or an election petition.

nlrb.gov · 1-844-762-6572

US DOL Wage & Hour · Stolen tips, off-clock work, unpaid wages.

dol.gov/agencies/whd · 1-866-487-9243

WRITE IT DOWN.

Keep a private, shared log of every violation.

DATE	TIME	WHO	WHAT HAPPENED

Our organizer: _____

Next meeting: _____

COPY IT.
FOLD IT.
PASS IT ON.

Solidarity is thicker than mud.



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github.com/Thicker-Than-Mud/thicker-than-mud

Not legal advice. Laws change; check with an organizer. Facts as of Winter 2026.